Fiche professeur

Passing the Flame. Othello, or the trap of theatrical illusion.

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Specialism LLCER English · Terminale of the lycée général et technologique

Programme of BO spécial n° 8 of 25 July 2019: thematic areas « Arts et débats d'idées » and « Expression et construction de soi » (axis « Mise en scène de soi »). Level C1.

Each ordinary lesson lasts 55 minutes and is timed on 52, with a stopping point and an eight-minute emergency exit. The midpoint commentary follows Lesson 5. Lesson 10 is the summative hour.

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Fiche professeur, spécialité LLCER anglais, Terminale of the lycée général et technologique. A C1 sequence on Shakespeare's *Othello*. Conçu par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac, mis en page par Grok.

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Guiding question. How does Shakespeare turn theatre itself into a trap of perception in *Othello*, and what does that trap still teach us about language, jealousy and the courage to read between the lines?

Programme. Bulletin officiel spécial n° 8 of 25 July 2019, spécialité LLCER anglais, Terminale: « Arts et débats d'idées », « Expression et construction de soi » (mise en scène de soi). The play is a demanding object, not a text presented as a programme limitatif.

Language of this sheet. British English throughout, by design. The dédicace and the note d'intention, in the students' booklet, remain in the exact French of the published source and are not to be translated as a class exercise.

How to run the sequence

Ten lessons of 55 minutes, timed on 52. A stopping point at about minute 44; an emergency exit of eight minutes in every lesson, still demanding, so that no student leaves without a finished thought. The midpoint commentary is sat after Lesson 5 (it may occupy a separate hour if the timetable allows). Lesson 10 is the summative hour.

The phrase « spirale de Gorse » is kept in French. Credit, whenever the diagram is shown: Méthode de la spirale de Gorse conçue par Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac.

Text. Project Gutenberg ebook 1531, public domain. Students may align line numbers with the Folger Digital Text. Do not quote long passages from copyrighted critics. Translation: François-Victor Hugo only. Never Yves Bonnefoy, never Jean-Michel Déprats.

What was added beyond an eight-lesson draft. Lesson 3 (the Senate, I.3) and Lesson 5 (mandatory close reading of III.4). Lesson 9 restores public-domain critics and Hugo. The pitch is C1 throughout, without a lower-tier core. The LLCER 2019 frame replaces any mistaken appeal to a 2025 LVA programme as the primary anchor. Vocational or other-pathway appendices are not included: the standing design is a LLCER C1 sequence, with a separate accessible version (version dys) that can be used on its own.

Course Hero documents. A student essay on III.4 and a nine-page teacher's analysis were consulted for ideas only, and never copied. The teacher's analysis does not treat III.4 itself (no moist hand, no Egyptian charmer). The III.4 close reading in the students' booklet is original.

Video essay. About five minutes, by Madame Carole Paoli Pompougnac: homage to Professor Pierre Spriet (Bordeaux III) and to the RSC at Stratford, 1984-85 (including Ben Kingsley's *Othello*). Play it twice in Lesson 1 if the room allows.

Painting. Chassériau, *Othello et Desdémone à Venise*, 1849-1850, Louvre RF 3897, public domain. Treat it as a first exercise in looking, not as a plot illustration.

House habits. No long dashes in materials you add. Say « lycée général et technologique ». Vocabulary headings only: « Expanding your vocabulary » or « Building your vocabulary ». Write « students » and « lessons ». Call the short close an emergency exit, and the minute-44 mark a stopping point.

Before the first lesson

- Print or share the students' booklet, the accessible version if needed, and this sheet.
- Check that the video file plays without depending on a live stream.
- Decide whether the midpoint will be a separate hour.
- Have a public-domain Hugo text available for Lesson 9 (a printed extract of I.1 is enough).
- Read the model close readings in the students' booklet: they are for the class, in a prépa spirit, and should not be handed out as a substitute for the students' own writing before the attempt.

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Lesson by lesson: intention, pitfalls, board, emergency exit

Lesson 1. Inheriting a way of reading

Intention. To set a tone of homage without sentimentality, and a method of looking. The diagnostic already asks for C1 precision.

Pitfalls. A class that only praises the video; a reading of Chassériau as « Othello is jealous ». Keep students to pictorial facts. Do not translate the dédicace.

On the board. The guiding question; turn 1 of the spiral; three words: seeing, interpreting, knowing.

Emergency exit. Three sentences (fact, inference, open question).

What to collect. The diagnostic (180-220 words). A possible standard is in the correction sheet.

Lesson 2. « I am not what I am »

Intention. The line as a contract with the spectator. The biblical echo (Exodus 3:14) is to be noticed and then returned to the theatre, not made into a sermon.

Pitfalls. Reducing Iago to a list of motives; moralising (« he is evil ») without rhetoric; letting the class enjoy the villain without noticing that this enjoyment is already the trap.

On the board. The last five lines, clearly written; the words *outward*, *sleeve*, *daws*, *I am*.

Emergency exit. Paraphrase, privilege, is the privilege safe?

Lesson 3. The Senate (new)

Intention. Without I.3, later work on proof and on « Haply, for I am black » lacks its first public scene. Teach the tale as testimony and as art; Desdemona's « visage in his mind »; Brabantio's seed; the pledge and the appointment of Iago.

Pitfalls. A clumsy discussion of race. The class can and must speak about otherness, « Moor », and « Haply, for I am black » (the last is in III.3, prepared here) with historical care and without sensationalism. Do not flatten Othello into a symbol.

On the board. The chiasmus of love; Brabantio's couplet; « My life upon her faith. »

Emergency exit. Four quotations in a chain, plus one sentence on public trust.

Lesson 4. The desire for proof

Intention. III.3 as a re-education of looking. The green-eyed monster as a warning that suggests; « Haply, for I am black » as an interiorising of a public gaze; ocular proof as a reasonable and fatal demand.

Pitfalls. Plot summary of the whole act; psychology off the page (« he has a complex »). Keep to verse and method.

On the board. *Ocular proof*; the green-eyed monster; one sentence: a demand for evidence can hide a wish to be confirmed.

Emergency exit. Six-line commentary on « ocular proof ».

Lesson 5. III.4, mandatory close reading (new)

Intention. This is the heart of the completed sequence. Follow the order in the students' booklet. Do not let the handkerchief be treated as a mere accessory. Press the three hypotheses about the Egyptian tale (lore, intimidation, a mixture). Press Emilia's silence.

Pitfalls. Inventing a « real » history of the cloth that the play does not settle; psychologising Othello's childhood; skipping Emilia. The moist-hand speech needs humoral context in one or two precise sentences, then a formal reading (over-reading, devil in the palm, heraldry).

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On the board. « I know not, madam. »; « a young and sweating devil »; « our new heraldry is hands, not hearts »; « what and if it were? »; « jealous for they are jealous ».

Emergency exit. Four moves (lie; moist hand; magic in the web; self-begotten monster) and a sentence on trust.

After this lesson. Midpoint commentary, 55 minutes (question printed in the booklet). Grid in this sheet and in the correction sheet. A full model is in the correction sheet; do not distribute it before the attempt.

Lesson 6. Directing the spectator

Intention. IV.1 as a play within the play whose spectator is the victim. The model close reading is one of the four promised in the note d'intention.

Pitfalls. A noisy « acting out » that loses kinds of knowledge. A simple diagram of positions is more rigorous than a full staging if time is short.

On the board. Three positions, three kinds of knowledge. The Lesson 10 question, already: « How does Shakespeare make Othello a spectator of his own deception? »

Emergency exit. The three-column table.

Lesson 7. One conversation, two meanings

Intention. Bianca and the handkerchief as a third meaning of the object (a pattern to be copied). Two referents in one conversation.

Pitfalls. Moralising Bianca. Keep to referent and assigned story.

On the board. Two columns: said / heard. The word *referent*.

Emergency exit. Three rows and a concluding sentence.

Lesson 8. The language of justification

Intention. « Put out the light » as a word turned; the last speech as a last mise en scène of the self. The Judean / Indian crux: name it, do not settle it casually. Gutenberg 1531 reads *Judean*.

Pitfalls. A pious or a cynical reading of the last speech. Hold both the request for a just report and the art that supplies its own images.

On the board. The doubled *light*; « Speak of me as I am »; the crux in one careful line.

Emergency exit. Six lines on one of the two passages.

Lesson 9. Critics and Hugo

Intention. Public-domain critics only, for long or medium quotation. Students answer the critic. Hugo for translation choices, not for error-hunting. Frye and Girard: invitations, as in the video, not long quotes.

Pitfalls. Name-dropping; treating Coleridge's phrase as a magic key; a translation class that only says « French is different ».

On the board. The comparative table (critic; what he sees; what he misses; a answering line).

Emergency exit. A paragraph answering Rymer, using Lesson 5.

Hugo. Have a public-domain extract ready. If a particular classroom edition is missing, read the English aloud and supply Hugo's last clause from a PD printing. Do not improvise a French translation of your own and attribute it to Hugo.

Lesson 10. Summative

Intention. A full commentary and a short director's oral. If time remains, open the tip of the spiral with intellectual restraint: no easy « application » to the day's news.

Pitfalls. Exhaustion; a moral that closes the play. The emergency exit is already written in the booklet.

Collection. Scripts and, if recorded, the oral. Grids below.

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Marking grids (teacher's copy)

Midpoint, out of 20: thesis and organisation 5; knowledge of III.4, 5; form and device 5; language 5.

Summative commentary, out of 20: thesis and guiding question 5; range and accuracy 5; dramatic and rhetorical analysis 5; language and humility 5.

Oral director's commentary, out of 10: scene and verse 4; staging idea 3; acknowledgement of a risk 3.

Allow a full C1 range. Do not punish a student who, in humility, leaves the Egyptian tale or the textual crux unsettled, if the unsettledness is argued.

Differentiation

The accessible version (version dys) covers all ten lessons, is usable alone, and keeps the same guiding question and the same texts. It shortens some written tasks, clarifies layout, and avoids dense blocks. It does not lower the intellectual demand to a different programme. In the main class, emergency exits protect students in difficulty without offering a parallel, weaker sequence. Gifted or prépa-bound students can be asked to write the optional Hugo passage (the moist-hand speech) and to take the Judean / Indian crux as a short note.

What not to do

- Do not frame the sequence at a lower CEFR band than C1.
- Do not replace the 2019 LLCER programme with another syllabus as the main anchor.
- Do not copy commercial study guides, including any Course Hero page.
- Do not use copyrighted long quotations.

Credit and method

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